

MASK SLIP

a feature screenplay

Story by Zoe Miller

Screenplay draft - Full Length Revision (Draft 2)

Based on the song "The Mask" by Zoe Miller [zoemcreative](#)
(YouTube)

*"Put off that mask of burning gold
With emerald eyes."*

*"O no, my dear, you make so bold
To find if hearts be wild and wise,
And yet not cold."*

*"I would but find what's there to find,
Love or deceit."*

*"It was the mask engaged your mind,
And after set your heart to beat,
Not what's behind."*

-- W.B. YEATS, "The Mask"

FADE IN:

INT. UNKNOWN SPACE - FLASH

Darkness thick enough to have weight. Then a rectangle of gold light, close, like a doorway seen through water -- or a doorway seen from underneath it.

A WOMAN'S HAND rises into frame, fingers spread against the light. Behind the hand, where a wall should be, the dark doesn't sit still. It moves the way smoke moves in a room with no fire in it, gathering at the edges of the gold instead of drifting through it, patient, almost curious, the way something waits outside a door it already knows will open.

The light SPLITS. A jagged white seam races corner to corner, silent, too fast to be glass and too slow to be lightning.

For one frame, in the seam itself, something looks back that is not the hand's owner.

BLACK.

THREE WEEKS EARLIER

EXT. LOS ANGELES - DAY

The city from altitude, all of it at once -- sun flattening the basin into sheet metal, glass towers throwing the light back at the sky like they're returning something they were only ever borrowing. Beautiful, and beautiful the specific way a held breath is beautiful, right before it isn't anymore.

Between two towers, too brief to be sure of, a wisp of something darker than shadow drifts against the wind instead of with it, and is gone before the eye can argue with it.

Nine million people under all that gold light go on about their day, sun-warmed, glass-walled, none of them looking up.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT

A one-bedroom walk-up stacked with cheap monitor speakers, a keyboard missing two keys, a corkboard of ticket stubs and gallery postcards. Rain on the window, real rain, recorded rain -- it's impossible to tell which.

MIA MERCER, 22, sits cross-legged on the floor in headphones, eyes closed, one hand on a mixing knob she isn't turning. Just resting there. Listening for something under the sound.

She nudges the knob a hair's width. A low frequency drops half a step.

Her shoulders come down an inch. Something in her chest lets go that she didn't know was held.

She opens her eyes. Writes nothing down. She already has what she came for.

EXT. ECHO PARK - RESERVOIR PATH - MORNING

Water flat as glass, sun coming off it in sheets. Mia runs. Same route, same time, same JOGGER passing her going the other way -- same pace, same half-smile, same nod, like a loop that hasn't noticed it's a loop.

On the water's surface, where her own shadow should fall long and single behind her, there are, for three strides, two.

She doesn't clock it. Nobody does.

INT. CAFE - CONTINUOUS

A BARISTA hands Mia a coffee with a smile that doesn't quite finish arriving before the next customer gets the identical one.

BARISTA

You're exactly where you should
be today.

It's printed on the cup sleeve. An ad. Mia doesn't read it. We do.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - LECTURE HALL - DAY

A packed intro psych elective. PROFESSOR OKONKWO, 50s, unhurried, clicks to a slide: a simple four-quadrant diagram. MACHIAVELLIANISM. NARCISSISM. PSYCHOPATHY. SADISM.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

The Dark Tetrad doesn't announce itself. That's the whole design flaw in how we teach people to spot it -- we go looking for a monster and miss the guy who's simply never once, in his entire life, run out of charm.

A student's hand goes up.

STUDENT (O.S.)

So how do you actually tell.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

You don't, watching him. You tell by counting the wreckage he's standing in and noticing he's the only person in the room who isn't confused about how it got there.

Another hand. A different student, half-joking, testing the room.

STUDENT #2 (O.S.)

Is there, like, a playbook? For when you finally do catch on?

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

There's an acronym if you want one. DARVO. Deny, Attack, Reverse Victim and Offender. He didn't do it -- and if he did, you made him -- and also, somehow, by the end of the sentence, you're the one who owes the apology. It works because it's fast. By the time you've caught up to what just happened, you're already three sentences into defending yourself for something you didn't do.

A ripple of uneasy laughter -- half the room recognizing something from a group chat, a family dinner, a breakup they still haven't fully explained to themselves.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO (CONT'D)

Write it down if it helps. Most people only recognize the pattern in hindsight, which is the design, not the flaw.

Mia writes this down word for word, underlines it twice. Something about it lands harder than lecture notes usually do.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - STUDIO - DAY

A sun-bright studio, half life-drawing, half sound lab -- a school that never picked a lane and is better for it. Mia sketches a seated MODEL, but her eyes keep going to the tension pooling in his left shoulder, not the shape of it.

Her friend DESI ARELLANO, 23, paint-stained, drops onto the stool beside her, unbothered by whose studio time this technically is.

DESI

You didn't answer me last night.

MIA

I was working.

DESI

You were listening to rain for
four hours.

MIA

That's working.

Desi steals a look at the sketch -- the shoulder, rendered
in obsessive, anatomically unnecessary detail.

DESI

You're doing the thing again.
Drawing what somebody's carrying
instead of what they look like.

MIA

It's more accurate.

DESI

It's why you dated a human
weather system for eight months
and called it chemistry.

Mia doesn't argue. She just keeps drawing the shoulder.

MIA

I start the internship Monday.

DESI

The insurance thing.

MIA

Halcyon. It's one semester. It
pays.

DESI

(a beat, careful)
You okay? Since Theo.

MIA

I'm fine.

She says it the way people say it when the sentence is doing all the work the feeling isn't.

DESI

You still haven't deleted his number.

MIA

(too fast)

I've deleted his number.

Desi holds out a hand, not unkindly. Mia hesitates a full three seconds before she pulls out her phone, finds the contact, and actually does it, right there, like ripping off tape.

MIA (CONT'D)

Happy?

DESI

Working on it. Come out tonight
-- Gilt. Not to meet anyone. Just
to be somewhere with a pulse.

Mia looks back at the shoulder on the page. Sets the pencil down.

MIA

Fine. One drink.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - EVENING

Mia gets ready fast, unceremonious about it -- no elaborate ritual, just the same headphones from her floor an hour ago, a different playlist, one low frequency she lets run under everything else while she dresses, the way some people hum without noticing.

Her phone buzzes. THEO. A single word: "Miss you." No punctuation, no context, arriving out of a silence that's lasted three weeks for a reason.

She looks at it a long moment. Doesn't reply. Doesn't delete it either, not yet -- just sets the phone face-down

on the dresser, a small, private rehearsal for a gesture she doesn't know she'll make again, for a different man, without remembering she ever practiced it.

She pulls her coat on, kills the music mid-phrase, and heads out into a night that hasn't decided yet what it's going to hand her.

EXT. GILT - NIGHT

A converted warehouse on the east side, gold light spilling off brick that's older than the neighborhood's new money. No sign, just a line and a door that opens for some people faster than others.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Low ceiling, bar close enough to the dance floor to feel complicit. No costumes, nothing literal -- just a room that's decided, without saying so, that it's older and stranger than a Tuesday night has any right to be. Ivy real and fake tangled along a mezzanine rail. Wine-dark light.

Mia and Desi at the bar. Desi already three sentences into a story Mia isn't fully in.

Across the room, a SCUFFLE starts -- two men, chest to chest, a spilled drink escalating past what a spilled drink is worth.

DIMITRIS XYDIAS, 41, cuts through the crowd before the bouncers do. Expensive, unbothered, dressed like money that stopped trying to prove itself years ago. He doesn't grab anyone. He just arrives, close, low-voiced, a hand light on one man's shoulder.

We don't hear what he says. We watch it work. The tension drains out of both men's spines like he's found a knob and turned it. Laughter, an arm around a shoulder, a fresh round on someone's tab.

He didn't stop a fight. He redirected two people's whole nervous systems in real time, and neither of them noticed

they'd been handled.

Mia noticed. She's still watching when he turns and, without any visible transition, points that same warmth at her.

DIMITRIS

You're the only person in this room who watched that like it was a magic trick instead of a bar fight.

MIA

Wasn't it?

DIMITRIS

(a real laugh,
surprised into it)

Dimitris.

MIA

Mia.

DIMITRIS

Mia.

He says it like he's turning it over, testing the weight of it.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

You know what that means. In a couple of languages.

MIA

Mine. I know.

DIMITRIS

I wasn't going to say it like that.

MIA

Sure you weren't.

He grins -- caught, charming about being caught, which is its own kind of disarming. Desi materializes at Mia's elbow, protective radar up.

DESI
We're leaving in ten.

DIMITRIS
(to Desi, easy)
I'm not going to be the reason
you're late.

(to Mia)
I hope I see you again.

He's gone before she can ask what he does, where he's from, anything with a hook in it. Mia watches the space where he was a beat too long.

EXT. GILT - NIGHT (LATER)

Mia and Desi walking home, buzzed, the good kind of tired.

DESI
So who was that.

MIA
I don't even know his last name.

DESI
That's not a no.

MIA
(fighting a smile and
losing)
He broke up a fight with, like, a
hand on a shoulder. Who does
that.

DESI
Someone who's done it a hundred
times before.

MIA
(too quickly, too
pleased)
Or someone who's just good with
people.

Desi gives her a look -- the specific look of a best friend who's heard this exact tone of voice describe the wrong men before and is choosing, tonight, not to say so.

DESI
Just -- go slow. That's all.

MIA
It was one conversation.

DESI
I know. I'm saying it anyway.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT

Mia, still in her coat, searches his name first. DIMITRIS XYDIAS. A handful of results -- a charity gala photo, a headshot from an old company newsletter, nothing recent, nothing that tells her anything a stranger couldn't guess.

She stops on the gala photo. Zooms in without deciding to. For one half-second, something about the angle of the jaw doesn't match the angle of the smile above it, like two separate photographs badly aligned. She blinks. Zooms out. It's just a photo, compressed too many times, degraded the way old photos degrade.

She closes the tab and looks up Halcyon Mutual instead, before her first day -- standard due diligence. Employee reviews load: five stars, five stars, five stars, a wall of nearly identical praise. "GREAT CULTURE." "GREAT CULTURE." "MANAGEMENT REALLY CARES."

One three-star review, buried on page four, says only: "Ask around before you take an offer here. Some people know things." No elaboration. No replies. Deleted, probably, if she checks back tomorrow, though she has no reason yet to check back tomorrow.

She closes the laptop, unbothered, the way anyone closes a laptop on a stray review from a stranger with nothing else to say.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - MORNING

First-day nerves dressed up as calm. Mia runs her ritual before she can talk herself out of it -- headphones on, one hand on the knob, three slow breaths, the same private tuning she does before anything that matters.

She catches her reflection in the dark monitor screen, adjusts her collar, practices a version of her own face that reads as competent instead of terrified. It's a small, ordinary vanity, the kind everyone allows themselves before a first day.

Behind her reflection, for one frame too brief to be sure of, the room looks like it has one more shadow in it than the furniture accounts for. She doesn't turn around. First-day nerves. That's all it is, probably.

She grabs her bag and heads out the door already rehearsing a handshake.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - LOBBY - DAY

A Bunker Hill tower, glass and cold marble, the kind of lobby built to make everyone in it feel briefly insured against everything. Mia, dressed for a job she's nervous about, waits with four other INTERNS.

An HR COORDINATOR checks a clipboard.

HR COORDINATOR
Claims track goes with Mr.
Xydias's team, fourth floor.

The name lands on Mia like a held note she can't place yet.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - DIMITRIS'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

A furious CLAIMANT, 50s, mid-rant across the desk from Dimitris -- tailored, controlled, a different animal from the man at Gilt only in wardrobe. Under the desk, out of the claimant's sightline, his phone lights twice with two different names. He doesn't look down. He doesn't need to.

CLAIMANT

Six weeks. Six weeks of nothing
from this company.

DIMITRIS

(warm, specific,
unhurried)

You're right. That's not
acceptable, and I'm not going to
pretend the process served you
the way it should have. I'm
reassigning your file to my desk
personally today.

The claimant deflates, disarmed by being agreed with instead of managed. Dimitris hasn't promised anything the company can't already do. He's just made it sound like a gift.

The door opens. The HR COORDINATOR leads in the new interns. Mia's eyes find him before the introduction does.

HR COORDINATOR

Mr. Xydias, your new intern. Mia
Mercer.

Dimitris looks up. For exactly one frame, something crosses his face that isn't surprise and isn't quite delight either -- calculation, gone as fast as it arrives, replaced by the practiced version of both.

DIMITRIS

Mia.

MIA
(careful, controlled)
Mr. Xydias.

DIMITRIS
Dimitris is fine. We're going to
be spending a lot of time in the
same room.

The claimant, forgotten, watches this exchange with the mild confusion of a man who's just realized he wasn't actually the main character of his own meeting.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Mia, walking the new-hire orientation loop with the other interns, passes a cluster of SENIOR STAFF by the coffee station.

SENIOR STAFF MEMBER #1
Xydias take you?

MIA
(surprised to be
recognized)
Yeah. How'd you know?

SENIOR STAFF MEMBER #1
(warm, easy, entirely
sincere)
He always gets the good ones.
Best manager on this floor,
honestly. Man remembers
everyone's kid's names, brings
the whole team lunch on bad
quarters out of his own pocket.
You got lucky.

SENIOR STAFF MEMBER #2
(joining in, nodding)
HR loves him. Zero complaints in
what, six years?

The two of them move on, entirely genuine, entirely convinced. Nobody in this hallway is lying. That's the part that will matter later -- an entire floor of decent people, all separately, honestly certain he's the best of them.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - ELEVATOR - LATER

Mia rides down alone, exhausted in the specific way a first day is exhausting. Mirrored walls, fluorescent hum. She catches her own reflection, tired, fine.

Then -- for one flicker, in the mirror behind her own reflection, a SECOND shape where Dimitris stood in the hallway a moment ago. Its face doesn't quite match the angle of the body. A dark wisp curls off one shoulder of it like smoke coming off something that isn't burning. Gone before she can be sure she saw any of it.

She blinks. Looks again. Just an elevator. Just fluorescent light doing what fluorescent light does.

She decides she imagined it, the way people decide that, every day, about the one thing they didn't imagine.

On the drive home, the sun going down turns every glass tower on the skyline the same molten gold, the whole city briefly on fire and calling it sunset.

The same billboard she's passed a hundred times catches her eye for the first time -- a smiling family, a slogan she's never actually read until now: YOU'RE EXACTLY WHERE YOU SHOULD BE. Same words as the coffee sleeve, verbatim, like the whole city ordered from the same script.

She doesn't clock the repetition. She's thinking about an elevator.

INT. MIA'S CAR - PARKED - NIGHT

Mia, engine off, on the phone with her MOTHER (V.O.) -- warm, distracted, clearly mid-chore on the other end.

MOTHER (V.O.)
(over the phone, easy)
How's the internship. Real job,
or coffee-and-copies job.

MIA
Real, so far. My supervisor's --

She stops herself before the sentence finishes, unsure
why.

MOTHER (V.O.)
Your supervisor's what.

MIA
Intense. In a good way. He's easy
to be around.

MOTHER (V.O.)
(a familiar, gentle
warning, worn smooth
from use)
That's what you said about the
last one. And the one before
that.

MIA
(too quick)
This isn't that.

MOTHER (V.O.)
(not pushing, just
remembering out loud)
You were seven and you gave Katie
Broussard your library card
because hers had a hold on it and
she wanted the book more. You
didn't even like the book. I used
to think that was just kindness.

(a beat, gentler)
Tell me his name sometime. Not
tonight. Just sometime.

Mia doesn't have a comeback for that one either. She just sits with the library card story a second longer than she means to.

MIA

I love you. I have to go.

She hangs up before her mother can say it a third way.
Sits in the dark car a moment longer than she needs to.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - FOURTH FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

Doors open. Dimitris is there, waiting, like he timed it.

DIMITRIS

I requested you for my team
specifically. Out of the intake
pool.

MIA

Is that normal?

DIMITRIS

No.

(a beat, disarming
honesty)

I wanted to see if the person who
watched that room like a magic
trick was as sharp with numbers
as she is with people.

MIA

And?

DIMITRIS

Ask me again in six weeks.

He holds the elevator door with two fingers, an old-world
courtesy that reads, in this light, like something closer
to a hand held open.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

Welcome to Halcyon, Mia.

He says her name like he already owns something about it. She steps past him into the hallway, and for the length of one shared look, neither of them looks away first.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

INT. DIMITRIS'S LOFT - ARTS DISTRICT - NIGHT

Exposed brick, museum-clean concrete floors, furniture that costs more for looking like it doesn't try. Nothing personal on the walls. Nothing personal anywhere.

ASTRID VANCE, late 20s, curled on the couch in one of his shirts, laughing at something on her phone. Dimitris beside her, present in the way a man is present when he's already thinking about somewhere else.

ASTRID

My mom wants me home for a few weeks. Before the wedding season starts and I never see her again till Christmas.

DIMITRIS

Go. I'll survive.

ASTRID

(teasing, certain)
Will you, though.

DIMITRIS

(a practiced smile)
Barely.

His phone lights up on the coffee table, face-down, fast. He doesn't turn it over. Astrid doesn't notice. She has no reason to.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - CLAIMS FLOOR - DAY

Mia at a borrowed desk, buried in a file. Dimitris drops another folder on top of it, close enough that his shoulder brushes hers -- not quite an accident, not quite not.

DIMITRIS

This one's a gray area. Client's story doesn't fully square with the timeline, but the payout's small enough nobody upstairs will look twice.

MIA

So what do you want me to do with it?

DIMITRIS

I want you to tell me what you'd do. Not what the manual says.

Mia studies the file. A small test dressed as trust.

MIA

I'd flag the discrepancy.

DIMITRIS

(genuinely pleased)

Good. That's the right answer.

(a beat)

It's also not what I need today.

He takes the file back before she can ask what that means, already walking away, already certain she'll let it go. She does.

Alone at her desk a moment later, Mia stares at the space where the file used to sit. She got the answer right and it changed nothing about what happens next -- her first real lesson in a system she hasn't named yet, where being correct and being listened to turn out to be two entirely separate skills.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - CLAIMS FLOOR - DAY (LATER)

A team meeting breaking up. Dimitris, in front of the whole floor, singles Mia out.

DIMITRIS

Mia's going to be sitting in on
the Kessler file review from now
on. Client-facing.

A ripple among the other interns -- a young intern named PRIYA, 22, doesn't quite hide the flash of hurt on her face. She's been here three months longer than Mia and knows it.

PRIYA

(quiet, to another
intern, not quite
quiet enough)

Must be nice.

Mia hears it. Doesn't know what to do with it. Dimitris, already three desks away, doesn't hear it at all, or doesn't let himself.

EXT. GRAND CENTRAL MARKET - DAY

Daylight, ordinary, no champagne, no gold light -- just two people eating tacos standing up at a counter, easy in a way that has nothing to perform for anyone.

DIMITRIS

(mouth half full,
unglamorous, real)

This is objectively better than
anything they've ever served me
at a business dinner.

MIA

Low bar.

DIMITRIS

Very low bar. I've been to
dinners that cost more than your
rent where the main character was
a foam.

She laughs, actually laughs, not the practiced kind. For one unguarded stretch, he isn't managing anything -- isn't performing wounded, isn't performing powerful, isn't performing anything at all. He's just a man enjoying tacos and her company on a Tuesday, and it is, of everything he's shown her so far, the most convincing thing yet.

MIA

You're different out here.

DIMITRIS

(a real, unguarded
beat)

Everyone's different out of the
room they're usually in.

It's the truest sentence he says all night, and neither of them notices it as a warning.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - RECITAL HALL - NIGHT

A student sound-design showcase, folding chairs, proud parents, a small crowd. Mia at a mixing board in the back, running her own piece live -- the same layered rain-and-synth work she was still tuning cross-legged on her apartment floor weeks ago, finished now, aired in public for the first time.

Desi watches from the front row. Near the back, unannounced, in a blazer that's slightly too good for a college recital hall, Dimitris slips in.

Mia sees him mid-set and nearly loses the fader. She doesn't. The piece lands, the small crowd applauds, genuinely warm.

Afterward, in the hallway:

DIMITRIS

That was the best thing in that room by a wide margin, and I include the woman before you who played actual cello.

MIA

You didn't have to come.

DIMITRIS

I wanted to hear what you sound like when nobody's paying you to be somewhere.

For once, it doesn't feel like a line. It feels like the truth, which is exactly what makes it work on her completely.

DESI

(arriving, sizing
Dimitris up in three
seconds flat)

You must be the supervisor.

DIMITRIS

(effortlessly warm,
extending a hand)

Dimitris. You must be the best friend who's heard entirely too much about me.

DESI

(not shaking it yet)

I've heard exactly the right amount, actually.

He laughs like it's charming instead of a warning shot. Desi doesn't laugh back. Mia, caught in the middle, chooses not to notice the temperature difference between the two reactions.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - BREAK ROOM - DAY (EARLIER)

Priya, alone with a microwave burrito, waves Mia over without much enthusiasm behind it -- the friendliness of two people ranked against each other who've decided not to let that be the whole relationship.

PRIYA

You're doing the Kessler file now. He give you the whole speech about trusting your gut over the manual?

MIA

Something like that.

PRIYA

(not quite a warning,
not quite not one)

He gave me that speech in month two. Felt like being handed a key to somewhere. Took me a while to notice it was a key to a room he could lock me back out of whenever he wanted.

MIA

That's not -- he's not like that with me.

PRIYA

(no bitterness in it,
which is somehow
worse)

I didn't either. Ask me again in six months.

She says it lightly, already moving on to the burrito, already back to being nothing more than a colleague eating lunch. Mia doesn't have anywhere to put the sentence, so she sets it down somewhere she can find it again later, and doesn't.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - NIGHT

Talia at the rope, clipboard in hand, running the door like a border checkpoint. A HOPEFUL GUY, 20s, expensive shoes, tries his luck.

HOPEFUL GUY

I know the owner.

TALIA

(not even looking up)

Everyone knows the owner tonight.

Cute jacket, though.

She waves through the group behind him without a second look and lets him stand there. It isn't cruelty exactly. It's inventory management, and she's very good at her job.

Mia approaches, and the rope lifts before she's said a word -- Talia's already clocked whose company she keeps.

TALIA (CONT'D)

(to Mia, almost warm)

You're learning to walk like you belong here. Faster than most.

MIA

Is that a compliment?

TALIA

It's an observation. Ask me again in six months whether it was a compliment.

INT. GILT - VIP MEZZANINE - NIGHT

A private table above the floor, gold rope, better light. GENEVIEVE "GEN" MARLOWE, mid-30s, presides over it like she built the place herself, which in the ways that matter to this room, she basically did. TALIA VOSS, late 20s, works the rope at the top of the stairs, deciding who gets to be near Gen tonight.

Mia is here because Dimitris brought her, and everyone at the table clocks it without saying so.

GEN
(sizing Mia up, not
unkindly)
So you're the intern.

MIA
Mia.

GEN
I know. He mentioned you.

That lands harder than Gen means it to. Across the table, RAE OSEI, early 30s, watches the exchange over the rim of her glass, saying nothing, her face doing careful work to look like it isn't doing any work at all.

A WOMAN AT THE TABLE (30s, half-listening to three conversations) leans toward Gen.

WOMAN AT THE TABLE
Tell Astrid I said hi when she's
back from her mom's.

GEN
(easy, already moving
on)
She'll be gone till the end of
the month, I think.

The name passes through Mia like a name that means nothing yet. She files it without knowing she's filing it. Dimitris, three feet away, hears every word and doesn't so much as glance over -- which is its own kind of tell, if anyone were looking for one.

Rae is looking for one. Rae looks away first.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - CAFETERIA - DAY

Mia and Desi, trays untouched. Desi's been quiet too long, which is its own kind of loud.

DESI

You've been at Gilt four nights
this week.

MIA

It's not that many nights.

DESI

It's every night you're not at my
apartment or asleep.

MIA

(defensive, hearing
herself)

I like the people there. Gen's
actually really smart, she just
doesn't advertise it. Talia's --

DESI

I didn't ask about Talia.

A beat. Mia sets down her fork.

MIA

Say the thing you're not saying.

DESI

He's your boss. He's older than
both our dads combined,
basically. And you talk about him
like the sun rose because he
specifically decided to.

MIA

That's not fair.

DESI

(gently, which is
worse)

I know it doesn't feel fair.
That's usually how you can tell.

Mia doesn't have an answer for that one. She picks the
fork back up instead.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT

Candles, actual effort. Mia's cooked -- something too ambitious for the size of her kitchen, flour on her sleeve, a small triumph she's trying not to be too visibly proud of. Dimitris in the doorway with a bottle of champagne he's holding like he picked it specifically, which he did.

DIMITRIS

You didn't have to do all this.

MIA

I wanted to.

He steps in, takes in the apartment -- the corkboard, the mismatched chairs, the four monitor speakers in a room built for one -- with an attention that reads, in this light, like reverence.

They eat. It's easy in the way early things are easy, before either person has had to be anything but charming.

He pours the champagne himself, unprompted, like he needs his hands doing something.

DIMITRIS

There's someone. Was someone. Is someone, technically, until it isn't, which is close enough to isn't that I don't want it hanging over tonight without saying it out loud.

MIA

(careful, already
bracing)

Okay.

DIMITRIS

Astrid. We're on a break. Her family, some things that needed space. It's basically over. It's just messy to actually end a thing on paper when it's already over everywhere that matters.

He says it looking directly at her, no flinch, no rush -- a man handing over a hard truth, or a man who has said this exact sentence before and knows precisely how long to hold eye contact for it to land as honesty.

MIA

Thank you for telling me.

DIMITRIS

I wasn't going to let you hear it from someone at a table before you heard it from me.

He raises his glass. She raises hers. Neither of them names what they're toasting.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

To new things.

They drink. Whatever door was ajar between them swings the rest of the way open.

Later -- plates cleared, candles lower. He stands at the door, coat on, the version of a night that's ending well.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

This was -- thank you. Genuinely.

He kisses her, unhurried, and goes. The door closes. Mia stands alone in her own kitchen, unreadable, one hand still on the counter. The champagne bottle sits open, half full.

She doesn't move to clean up. She's listening to something.

Her phone buzzes on the counter.

INSERT - PHONE SCREEN

DIMITRIS

I'm three steps from the car and
I don't want to be.

BACK TO SCENE

The relief that crosses her face is bigger than the sentence should earn. She's already typing back before she's decided to.

A knock at the door, seconds later -- he never made it to the car at all.

She opens it. Doesn't say anything. Neither does he, for a moment. Then he's in, and the door's shut, and whatever was building all night finally has somewhere to go.

They kiss like the last hour was a formality. Clothes go the way clothes go when nobody's thinking about the floor they're landing on. The champagne bottle tips, forgotten, wine-gold liquid running unchecked across the counter and dripping, slow, to the tile -- an offering nobody poured on purpose.

Streetlight through the blinds throws one long shadow across the bed as he moves over her -- for a single frame, the shadow's edge catches the headboard's crossbar just wrong, a shape like a marionette's rig, gone the instant either of them would have noticed it.

It is, by any measure that matters in the room, real. Real heat, real want, nothing performed in it that either of them can feel. That's what makes it work. That's what always makes it work.

INT. DIMITRIS'S LOFT - ARTS DISTRICT - NIGHT (LATER)

Different night, same choreography, new address. Mia in his space now, wrapped in a sheet, looking at the walls -- still nothing personal on them. No photographs. No exes' toothbrush, no half-unpacked box, no sign that anyone else has ever stood exactly where she's standing.

MIA

You've lived here how long?

DIMITRIS

(from the bed, easy)

Three years.

MIA

It doesn't look lived in.

DIMITRIS

I like clean lines.

He says it like an aesthetic preference. It is not, in this apartment, an aesthetic preference. It's a policy.

She sets a glass down on the counter -- not quite where a coaster would go. He's up and moving it half a second later, smooth, barely a beat missed, wiping the ring of condensation away before it can set.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

(catching himself,
light)

Sorry. Habit.

MIA

(charmed, not alarmed)

You're very tidy for a man who
set a bar fight straight with one
hand.

DIMITRIS

I contain multitudes.

She laughs. He's already refilled her glass.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

(quieter, looking at
her like it costs him
something to say)

I don't usually let people into
this apartment. Let alone stay
the night. Whatever this is with
you, it's not something I do.

MIA

(genuinely moved)

Why me, then.

DIMITRIS

(a long, practiced
beat)

Honestly? I don't know. I've
never not known before.

It plays, in this room, like the most vulnerable thing a
guarded man has ever said to her. She files it away as
proof. We file it away as evidence.

The moment passes, filed by her under charming, filed by
us under something else.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - NIGHT (LATER)

A different kind of night -- Mia not on his arm yet, just
in the room, watching him work it before he's clocked her
arrival. He's magnetic in every direction at once: a hand
on a stranger's shoulder here, a low laugh shared with a
woman at the bar there, his attention landing on each of
them with the exact same unhurried weight he gave Mia at
her own kitchen table two nights ago.

A WOMAN AT THE BAR, 20s, laughs at something he says,
touches his arm, lingers a beat past casual. He lets her.
He doesn't correct the read, doesn't clarify anything,
doesn't do a single thing that could be pointed to later
as proof of wrongdoing. He just leaves the door open and
lets everyone in the room decide for themselves how far
through it they're allowed to walk.

He finds Mia across the room. The switch is instant and total -- for the length of one look, she is, again, the only person in the building.

DIMITRIS
(crossing to her,
easy)
There you are.

MIA
(a beat, watching the
woman at the bar drift
back to her friends)
You know her?

DIMITRIS
(genuinely unbothered)
I know everyone in this room.
That's sort of the job.

It's technically true and answers nothing. Mia lets it go, and tells herself the warmth he just turned on her weighs more than the warmth he hands the rest of the room. She has no way to weigh either one. She believes it anyway.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT (LATER)

Mia alone, unable to sleep, phone in hand, not texting him, just holding it, waiting for it to do something. She catches herself doing it and puts the phone down. Picks it back up ninety seconds later.

MIA
(to the empty room,
half a joke, half not)
This is what a rat in a maze
feels like.

She knows the term for it -- wrote it in a notebook months ago, underlined it twice. Intermittent reinforcement. Knowing the term doesn't loosen her hand off the phone even a little. She checks it a third time before she manages to put it face-down and leave it there.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - ROOFTOP - NIGHT

The firm's holiday party, string lights over a rented rooftop, the awkward blend of an office party trying to also be a real one. Mia in a nicer dress than she'd wear to a work function, which is itself a small confession.

Dimitris works the crowd exactly as he works Gilt -- same warmth, different costume, a hand on a shoulder here, a laugh at someone's joke there, the whole floor visibly grateful just to be near him tonight.

A PARTNER'S WIFE, 50s, warm and a little tipsy, corners Mia by the bar.

PARTNER'S WIFE

You're the intern he's been
talking about. The sharp one.

MIA

(pleased despite
herself)

He said that?

PARTNER'S WIFE

Practically the only thing he
says these days. It's nice,
honestly. Man works himself into
the ground, deserves someone
bright around to remind him why.

She wanders off before Mia can ask what "these days" is measured against, or against whom. Across the roof, Dimitris catches Mia's eye through the crowd and raises his glass an inch, just for her, gone again before anyone else clocks it.

Mia raises hers back. It is, in this exact moment, the best night of her year.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - BREAK ROOM - DAY

Mia gets coffee. Down the hall, through a half-open office door, she catches Dimitris mid-conversation with a junior ADJUSTER, 30s, visibly rattled.

DIMITRIS (O.S.)

That's not what I said in the meeting. I said we'd review it. You're the one who told the client it was approved.

ADJUSTER (O.S.)

(off, smaller)

I have the email --

DIMITRIS (O.S.)

(calm, total,
immovable)

Then you'll find it says what I just told you it says.

The adjuster leaves the office a moment later, pale, already rehearsing an apology to someone for a mistake that isn't his. Dimitris follows, unbothered, and passes Mia in the hallway with a smile that doesn't cost him anything.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

Long day for some people.

He keeps walking. Mia watches the adjuster's back retreat down the hall, something small and cold moving through her that she doesn't have a name for yet.

MIA

(to herself, quiet)

Huh.

She decides it's an office thing. Above her pay grade. Not her business.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - COPY ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The rattled ADJUSTER from before, alone at the copier, hands not quite steady, printing an apology email he's rewriting for the third time. Mia hovers in the doorway, unsure why she's stopped.

MIA

Are you okay?

ADJUSTER

(startled, then
careful, performing
fine)

Yeah. Just -- misremembered
something. My fault.

MIA

(gently)

Did you, though.

He looks at her a beat too long, like the question is a door he hasn't been offered in a while, and then, visibly, decides not to walk through it.

ADJUSTER

It's fine. He's fine. It's fine.

He says "fine" three times like a man convincing a jury of one. Mia lets it go, tells herself it's not hers to carry, and carries it anyway, quietly, for the rest of the day.

She goes back to her desk and, by the end of the afternoon, has mostly managed to file it away as an office thing after all.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT

Desi, over on the floor with a bottle of wine between them, watches Mia scroll through photos from the holiday rooftop with the specific focus of someone building a shrine without calling it one.

DESI

You look happy in these.

MIA

I am happy.

DESI

(carefully, not
accusing, just
checking)

Happier than with Theo?

MIA

(without hesitation,
which surprises her
too)

It's not even close. He remembers
things I said weeks ago. He asks
about my music like it's a real
thing and not a hobby I'll grow
out of.

DESI

(a beat, choosing her
words)

I believe you that it feels
different. I just want you to
notice that "he's not like the
others" is the thing everyone
says right before they find out
he's exactly like the others,
just better at it.

MIA

(a flash of real
defensiveness)

Or maybe some people are actually
just good.

DESI

Maybe. I hope so. I'm not saying
don't be happy. I'm saying keep
one eye open while you are.

Mia doesn't answer that directly. She goes back to the photos instead, and Desi lets her, filing her own worry away the same careless way Mia's been filing everything else lately -- for later, for someone else to deal with, for a version of tonight that doesn't have to be about this.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - NIGHT

Dimitris and Mia, closer now, easier in public than they've been -- not hiding exactly, just not naming it either. Gen watches from the mezzanine with an expression that isn't hostile yet, just recalibrating.

DIMITRIS

Next time, I want you at the table properly. Not borrowed for an hour. My people should actually know you.

MIA

Your people.

DIMITRIS

(a real, warm smile)

You'll like them. Everyone does, eventually.

Behind him, unseen, Rae watches the two of them with an expression that's stopped pretending not to be doing work at all.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

INT. GILT - VIP MEZZANINE - NIGHT

The rope lifts for Mia without her having to say a name. Talia clocks her walking through it, unbothered, filing the information the way a good doorkeeper files everything.

Gen's table is fuller tonight -- bottle service, sparklers in the necks of champagne, a small court assembling itself around Dimitris the way courts do, without anyone deciding to build one.

GEN

(raising a glass,
generous, absolute)

To the intern who isn't an intern
anymore.

The table drinks to Mia. She feels the warmth of being toasted by people who could just as easily not have bothered. It is, chemically, indistinguishable from being loved.

TALIA

(leaning in, easy)

You're at the table now. That's
not nothing. People wait years
for that seat.

MIA

I didn't do anything to earn it.

TALIA
(a real laugh)
Nobody does. That's not how the
seat works.

It's the most honest sentence anyone at this table says all night, and it slides past Mia like a compliment.

INT. PRIVATE PENTHOUSE - AFTERPARTY - LATER

Higher up, smaller room, the kind of after-hours space that exists specifically so the real party can happen once the public one's closed. Low bass, low light, bodies loose with champagne and whatever else the night's decided to run on.

Mia dances near the center of it, further in than she's ever let herself go in a room like this, Dimitris's hand at the small of her back like a compass she didn't ask to need.

The lights strobe once, twice -- and for a single frame, his face isn't quite his face. Something in the jaw, the eyes, wrong in a way she can't name, a thread of dark unspooling off his shoulder where the strobe should only be throwing white, before the light corrects itself and he's just Dimitris again, smiling down at her like nothing happened, because as far as he's concerned, nothing did.

She laughs it off. Attributes it to the champagne, the lights, the hour. That's what the hour is for.

INT. PENTHOUSE - LOUNGE CORNER - CONTINUOUS

A card table set up as a joke that half the room is taking seriously. SABLE REYES, 30s, a party fixture with a reputation for being "eerily good" at this, lays out tarot cards for whoever sits down, cold-reading with the confidence of someone who's never once been wrong because no one's ever checked.

Mia sits, half-dared into it by Talia.

SABLE

(flipping a card, easy
showmanship)

The Star. You've been wanting to
feel like you're finally, finally
the exception to something.

Mia's face does something involuntary. Sable doesn't
notice or doesn't care -- it's a party trick, not a
warning, and she delivers it like one.

SABLE (CONT'D)

Congratulations. Looks like you
are.

The table laughs, delighted. Mia laughs too, a beat too
late, already wanting it to be true more than she wants to
question how Sable knew to say it.

As the table breaks up, Sable catches Mia's sleeve, lower
now, the showmanship dropped for one sentence.

SABLE (CONT'D)

You work at Halcyon, right?
Claims side?

MIA

(surprised to be
asked)

Yeah, why?

SABLE

(a small, private
smile, already sliding
back into performance)

No reason. Small city, big
insurance company. Everybody ends
up filed somewhere eventually.

She's gone before Mia can ask what that means, back into
the crowd, dealing the next hand to the next willing
stranger. Mia files it as nothing. It is not nothing.

Across the room, Dimitris watches this with the satisfaction of a man watching a wish get granted that he didn't have to grant himself.

INT. GILT - SUB-BASEMENT - LATER

A door behind the DJ booth Mia's never seen open before. Dimitris leads her down a narrow stair into a low, close room -- no strobe here, no bass, just candlelight and a dozen of the same faces from the mezzanine, quieter down here, unmasked in a different sense of the word. GEN. TALIA. RAE, near the wall, watching Mia arrive the way she watches everything now.

DIMITRIS

(low, just for her)

Almost nobody gets shown this room. It's not a rule anyone wrote down. It's just -- earned.

MIA

What happens down here?

DIMITRIS

Nothing happens. That's the whole luxury of it. Up there, everyone's performing for each other. Down here, for one hour, nobody has to.

It should feel like the truth. For one full breath, it does -- the room genuinely quieter, genuinely warmer, the performance of the mezzanine sanded down to something that reads, convincingly, as rest. Mia lets her shoulders drop the way she hasn't let them drop in this building before.

Rae watches her do it, and doesn't say anything, because she remembers being handed exactly this room, exactly this feeling, exactly this many years ago, and there was no way to have told herself then either.

Someone pours from a bottle with no label. It goes around the circle hand to hand, no toast proposed out loud, just Dimitris raising his glass a half-inch and everyone else

following without being told to -- the whole room moving on a single unspoken cue, the way a flock turns.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

(quiet, almost
private, though
everyone hears it)

To the ones who actually see each other. There are fewer of us than people think.

Gen drinks like it's scripture. Talia drinks like habit. Rae drinks last, watching Mia over the rim of her glass, and doesn't finish hers.

The candlelight gutters once, all the flames at the same moment, though there's no draft down here to explain it. Nobody but Mia looks up to check.

EXT. MALIBU ESTATE - GARDEN - DUSK

A property that belongs to someone whose name nobody at this party says out loud, all glass and infinity edge and imported olive trees. Golf carts ferry guests up from the gate. Champagne again, always champagne, poured by staff who've been trained not to look at anyone too long.

Gen walks Mia through it like a tour guide who's decided Mia's worth the extra commentary.

GEN

Nobody who actually lives here is here tonight. That's sort of the point of a place like this. It exists to be borrowed.

MIA

Whose is it?

GEN

(a genuine laugh)

Does it matter? You're standing in it.

Across the lawn, at the infinity edge, Dimitris stands alone a moment, drink in hand, looking down at the water where the pool's black surface holds nothing but sky and his own outline. He doesn't move. A full ten seconds, then fifteen, someone calling his name twice from the terrace before he hears it -- as if the only thing standing between him and staying there all night was somebody else needing something from him first.

Mia clocks it. Says nothing. Files it the way she's filed everything else lately.

Talia intercepts them with two fresh glasses and a look for Mia that's warmer than usual.

TALIA

Dimitris wants you at the main table for the toast.

MIA

There's a toast?

TALIA

There's always a toast. Someone just has to decide who it's for.

INT. MALIBU ESTATE - MAIN HALL - NIGHT

Golden hour long gone, the room lit now by candles and something colder underneath the candlelight that doesn't have an obvious source. Forty, fifty people, all dressed like money that's decided tonight is a costume it's comfortable wearing.

Dimitris rises at the head of the table, glass raised, and the whole room quiets before he's said a word -- a silence that arrives on its own, the way weather arrives.

DIMITRIS

To the people who make a room worth being in. There aren't many. Most people just fill space.

He looks directly at Mia when he says it. The whole table follows his eyeline, and for one unbearable, gorgeous second, every person in this room is looking at her like she's the reason the night is happening.

He produces a small box, slides it down the table to her -- not jewelry, something stranger and more calculated: a key, brass, old-fashioned, to nothing she recognizes.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

To the studio upstairs.
Sound-treated, better gear than
your apartment will ever fit. Use
it whenever you want. I had it
built out for someone once. It's
been empty a while.

The table murmurs, impressed, a little envious. Mia turns the key over in her fingers, weightless and enormous at once.

MIA

(quiet, only to him)
Someone.

DIMITRIS

(a beat, smooth)
A long time ago. Doesn't matter
now.

She lets it go, the way she's gotten good at letting things go. The wish granted, exactly as advertised, comes with a shape she doesn't examine too closely -- a room built for someone else, handed to her like it was always going to end up in her hands.

Across the candlelight, for one flicker nobody else registers, the flame nearest his face gutters sideways, though there's no draft in the room to explain it.

Mia sees it. Decides, again, that she didn't.

INT. MALIBU ESTATE - TERRACE - LATER

Mia and Gen, alone, away from the noise, looking out at black water they can hear better than see.

GEN

(unguarded, a little
drunk, a little
honest)

I used to stand exactly here.
Younger than you, even. Thought
I'd found the only room in the
world worth being in.

MIA

Did you?

GEN

(a long pause)

I found a room. I'm still
deciding if it was the one I
thought it was.

It's the closest Gen has come to saying anything true all night, and neither of them follows it any further. Mia will remember this exact conversation later, and wish she'd asked one more question.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - MASQUE NIGHT

One night a year the club leans all the way into its own theater and calls it a theme: half-masks on every face, gold and black and blood-red feathers, a string quartet fighting the DJ for control of the room and losing beautifully. It should read as costume-party silly. In this light, in this crowd, it doesn't.

Mia, masked like everyone else, loses Dimitris in the crush and finds him again by instinct, the way she's learned to find him in any room now without trying. He's at the center of a loose circle of dancers, all masked, all moving around him like the room has quietly agreed he's the axis it turns on.

He pulls her in. They dance the way the whole room dances tonight -- unhurried, theatrical, a little too perfect, like choreography nobody rehearsed and everybody somehow already knows.

DIMITRIS

(against her ear,
warm, half-shouted
over the music)

Best night of the year. Everyone
gets to be exactly who they
already are and call it a
costume.

MIA

(laughing, breathless)
Who are you tonight, then?

DIMITRIS

(a beat, and for once
the charm drops half
an inch, something
older looking out from
behind it)

Same as every other night. I just
don't usually get permission to
show it.

The quartet hits a swell. The whole floor turns as one, masks catching the light at the same angle for a single unified second -- and for that second, every face in the room looks briefly, uncannily like his.

Mia blinks. It's gone. Just a crowded dance floor again, strangers in feathers and gold, nothing stranger than a theme night trying too hard.

She laughs it off and lets the music take the thought before it can finish arriving.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

A firm mixer disguised as team-building, bad wine in plastic cups standing in for the champagne two nights ago. The two worlds Mia's living in have started occupying the same physical room without her fully registering the collapse.

Dimitris works the space like he works Gilt -- same warmth, same redirect, different costume. He catches Mia's eye across the room and holds it half a second too long for a supervisor. Nobody else clocks it. Rae, near the door, does.

A JUNIOR ADJUSTER, the same one from the break room weeks ago, watches the two of them from across the plastic cups and bad wine, says nothing, and goes back to a conversation about quarterly numbers that clearly matters less to her than what she just saw. Mia doesn't notice her noticing. She's stopped scanning rooms for that kind of thing without deciding to stop.

INT. PRIVATE PENTHOUSE - AFTERPARTY - NIGHT

Later, deeper into the same rhythm of nights, indistinguishable from the others except that Mia's stopped counting them. The bass sits lower in her chest than it used to. She doesn't remember when that changed.

Dimitris pulls her close on the floor, both of them lit gold and blue by turns as the lights sweep the room. He leans in to say something into her ear she doesn't quite catch over the music.

For a full three seconds this time, not a flicker, not a strobe-frame, his face holds something that isn't his face at all: skin gone waxen and wrong, a second expression laid under the first like a photograph developing too fast, eyes with no bottom to them, and around his collar, unmistakable this time, the same dark wisp from the elevator mirror, thicker now, unhurried, at home.

Mia pulls back, genuinely rattled, the champagne doing nothing to soften it this time.

MIA
(shaken)
What was that.

DIMITRIS
(instantly warm,
instantly normal,
already reaching for
her hand again)
What was what?

He looks completely, convincingly fine. Around them,
nobody else has stopped dancing. Nobody else saw anything,
or if they did, nobody's letting on.

MIA
(quieter, to herself
more than him)
Nothing. Never mind.

She lets him pull her back into the rhythm of the room.
It's easier than the alternative. It is, every time,
easier than the alternative -- until, one of these nights,
it won't be.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT (LATER)

Mia at her desk, sketchbook out for the first time in
weeks, doing the thing Desi called out months ago --
drawing not a face but what a face is carrying. She isn't
drawing Dimitris. She's drawing the thing underneath him:
a second set of features laid under the first, waxen, eyes
with no bottom, rendered in the same obsessive,
anatomically unnecessary detail she once gave a stranger's
shoulder tension.

She doesn't show anyone. She doesn't caption it. She just
needs it to exist somewhere outside her own head, the way
she's always needed sound to exist outside her own head,
proof she isn't only imagining what she's carrying.

She tears the page out, folds it small, and puts it in the
same drawer where the corkboard's oldest ticket stubs live
-- not thrown away. Just not looked at yet.

INT. GILT - VIP MEZZANINE - NIGHT (EARLIER THAT WEEK)

Gen and Talia at the table, a text lighting Gen's phone. She reads it, and something crosses her face too fast for the table to fully clock.

TALIA

What.

GEN

(recovering, light,
not light enough)

Astrid's flight got moved up.
She's back Thursday.

The name lands on the table like a dropped glass nobody's cleaned up yet. Talia's eyes flick, once, to the empty end of the table where Mia usually sits.

TALIA

(carefully neutral)

Does he know?

GEN

He booked the flight.

Neither of them says anything else about it. Some sentences do all their damage in the silence that follows them.

INT. GILT - MEZZANINE - NIGHT (LATER)

The temperature in the room changes before anyone says a word.

ASTRID VANCE stands at the top of the stairs, back from her mother's, tanned, recovered, expecting to walk back into exactly the life she left. She finds Dimitris at the table with his hand loose around a glass, and Mia two seats down, comfortable, at home there in a way that takes Astrid exactly one second to clock.

Dimitris rises to greet her, warm, unbothered, already narrating.

DIMITRIS

(low, only to Astrid,
already ahead of the
question)

This is going to be awkward for
about thirty seconds and then it
isn't. Mia's one of my interns.
Sharp. Gen's basically adopted
her.

He's already told Astrid a version of this before tonight,
privately, carefully -- we don't need to see that
conversation to feel its fingerprints on this one.
Whatever it was, it did not include the word "girlfriend."

Astrid's eyes go to Mia and stay there. Not confused.
Certain, instantly, of something Dimitris is counting on
her not being able to prove.

ASTRID

(cool, precise)

Mia. Right. I've heard so much.

MIA

(genuinely unaware of
the weather she's
standing in)

All good, I hope.

ASTRID

(a smile with nothing
behind it)

Sure.

She sits. The table recalibrates around her the way a room
recalibrates around a returning queen who might not be
queen anymore and hasn't decided how to feel about it. Gen
glances between the two women, reading something she isn't
saying yet.

Dimitris, seated between them, is the calmest person at
the table. He has, after all, done this before.

INT. GILT - LADIES' ROOM - LATER

Mia at the mirror, fixing her lipstick. Astrid enters behind her, waits for the door to close, and drops the pleasant mask entirely -- not shouting, worse than shouting, ice-flat.

ASTRID

I don't know what he's told you.
I don't need to know. I just need
you to understand that I know
exactly what this looks like, and
I'm not going anywhere.

MIA

(caught off guard,
careful)

He told me you two were basically
done. That it was a mutual thing.

ASTRID

(a short, ugly laugh)

Of course he did.

For one second, something almost true passes between them -- two women, one sentence away from comparing notes that would blow the whole thing open. Astrid sees it too, and chooses, visibly, not to go there. It's easier to hate the woman in front of her than the man who isn't.

ASTRID (CONT'D)

Watch yourself.

She's gone before Mia can answer. Mia looks at her own reflection for a long moment -- rattled, and underneath the rattled, something uglier: a small, unwelcome flicker of triumph, that she's the one still standing in the room he came back to.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT (LATER)

Mia alone, unable to sleep, the apartment darker than usual -- one of the streetlights outside has gone dead. She lies still, staring at the ceiling, replaying Astrid's face in the mirror.

The temperature drops, not dramatically, just enough to notice. Her breath fogs, once, in a room with the heat on.

Across the room, in the black rectangle of her turned-off monitor, a shape moves that isn't her own reflection -- taller than she is, patient, standing exactly where a second person would stand if a second person were in the room with her.

She sits bolt upright. Flips the light on. Nothing. Empty apartment, same as always, heat working fine now, no fog on anyone's breath.

She doesn't call it a nightmare. She doesn't call it anything. She just doesn't turn the light back off for a long time.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - CLAIMS FLOOR - DAY

Mia's desk. Priya's is empty, cleared out, a cardboard box already gone. An HR memo sits open on Mia's screen -- a routine reassignment notice, bloodless, three sentences long.

She finds Dimitris in the break room.

MIA

What happened to Priya?

DIMITRIS

(barely looking up)

Performance issue. Not my call.

MIA

She was good. She trained me on half the intake system.

DIMITRIS

(a warm, closing
smile)

You're better. That's not a knock
on her. That's just where we are
now.

He says it like a compliment. It sits in Mia's stomach
like something else entirely. She doesn't push it further
-- there's no version of pushing it further that doesn't
also mean pushing at the ground she's currently standing
on.

INT. GILT - DJ BOOTH - NIGHT

A booth Mia's never been allowed behind before. Dimitris
leans in past the current DJ, murmurs something, and steps
back grinning as the DJ waves Mia up without question.

DIMITRIS

Fifteen minutes. Your set. I told
him to give you the good hour.

MIA

(genuinely stunned)
You can just do that?

DIMITRIS

(easy, like it's
nothing, because to
him it is)
I can just do that.

She plays. It's the track from the recital, deepened,
reworked for a room built to swallow sound whole instead
of a folding-chair auditorium -- and the floor actually
moves to it, actually responds, actual strangers with
their hands up for something she built alone on her
bedroom floor.

She looks for him in the crowd and finds him already
watching her, and for one entire song, the wanting to be
chosen and the being chosen collapse into the exact same
feeling, indistinguishable, permanent-feeling, false.

INT. GILT - BACKSTAGE - LATER

Mia, still lit up, finds Talia backstage restocking the bar.

MIA

Thank you. For letting that happen.

TALIA

(a genuine,
complicated smile)
Wasn't me who let it happen.

MIA

I know. Still. Thank you.

TALIA

(a beat, something
almost like a warning
wrapped in a
compliment)
You're good, by the way. Actually
good, not favor-good. Remember
that part, whatever happens with
the rest of it.

Mia doesn't ask what "the rest of it" means. She's too high on the fifteen minutes to want an answer that might complicate it.

Her phone buzzes. A video Desi sent from the crowd, shaky, thrilled, captioned only: "MY BEST FRIEND JUST PLAYED GILT???" Mia watches it twice, grinning, and for a moment the two halves of her life -- the one with Desi in it and the one with all of this in it -- feel, briefly, like the same life instead of two she's quietly been keeping in separate rooms.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - DAY (LATER)

Late morning, blinds still shut, Mia surfacing hours past when her alarm went off. Empty glasses on the nightstand that aren't only water glasses. Her phone, dead, plugged in only now.

Desi's texts light the screen the second it powers on -- four of them, increasingly worried, the last one just a question mark.

She showers too long, skips the class she had at nine, and stands in front of her own corkboard for a full minute like she's trying to remember whose life the ticket stubs belong to.

MIA

(quiet, to the empty
apartment)

It's fine. Everyone does this in
their twenties.

Nobody answers her, because nobody's there to. She says it again anyway, softer, like repetition is the same thing as belief.

INT. PENTHOUSE - AFTERPARTY - NIGHT (LATER, WEEKS ON)

The decadence has a rhythm now, familiar, comfortable -- Mia moves through this room like she belongs in it, because by every metric this world uses, she does. Champagne towers. A DJ nobody can name playing music that never quite ends, only changes shape. Gen's arm around her shoulders in a photo neither of them will remember taking.

Astrid is here too, across the room, always across the room, a fixed point Mia has learned to orbit without looking at directly. Dimitris moves easily between both halves of his life, choosing Mia's side of the room again and again without once making it a public statement -- which is its own kind of statement, and Mia reads every unspoken instance of it as proof.

MIA (V.O.)
(quiet, almost to
herself, over the
scene)

I kept thinking: he chose me. Out
of everyone in every room he's
ever been in. He chose me.

She doesn't see what the camera sees: that being chosen by
a man who is choosing, simultaneously, several other
people to feel exactly this same way, is not the same
thing as being chosen at all.

The night closes on Mia laughing, lit gold, further from
the ordinary world than she's ever been and happier there
than she's been anywhere else in years.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - CLAIMS FLOOR - NIGHT

Empty floor, most of the lights off, the building down to its bones. Mia at her desk, finishing late. Dimitris in the doorway of his office, a file in his hand.

DIMITRIS

The Reyes claim. I need you to move the incident date back four days. Small thing. Fixes an exclusion issue that's costing the client money they're owed anyway.

MIA

That's not a small thing. That's falsifying a record.

DIMITRIS

(pleasant, patient)

It's correcting an error in the client's favor.

MIA

I'm not signing that.

The pleasantness doesn't leave his face. It just stops reaching anywhere behind it.

DIMITRIS

(quiet, precise)

You signed an intern NDA on day one. You understand what that means for someone who decides to make my job harder than it needs to be.

There's no one else on the floor. No audience. Nothing to perform for. And for exactly three seconds, something underneath his voice goes wrong in a way that has nothing to do with anger -- flat, ancient, hungry, a register no office dispute has ever needed. The fluorescent panel over his office door dims a full shade, as if whatever just answered her needed the light for something else.

Mia's chair scrapes back half an inch before she's decided to move it.

Then it's gone. He's just a tired man in a nice suit again, mildly annoyed at an intern.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

(normal, already softening)

Sleep on it. We'll talk tomorrow.

He goes. Mia sits alone on the empty floor for a long moment, hands not quite steady, telling herself it was the fluorescent lights, the late hour, nothing.

She doesn't believe herself this time.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT (LATER)

Mia at her laptop, the glow of it the only light in the room. Her psych notebook open beside her, Professor Okonkwo's underlined sentence staring back up at her: YOU TELL BY COUNTING THE WRECKAGE.

She's built a document without deciding to build it -- a plain list, growing as she types. THE OFFICE. THE ADJUSTER. PRIYA. THE APARTMENT WITH NOTHING PERSONAL IN IT. ASTRID.

Underneath the list, almost involuntary, she writes four letters. DARVO. Then, beneath it, applies it line by line, the way the professor taught her -- deny (he never asked her to falsify anything, not in words she could quote back), attack (she's the one who's been distant, difficult, ungrateful), reverse victim and offender (somehow, by the end of every hard conversation, she's the one apologizing).

It fits her own life so exactly it stops feeling academic and starts feeling like a diagnosis with her name already filled in.

She stares at the list a long moment, then adds one more line, smaller than the others, like she's hoping it won't count as much if it's in a smaller font: ME.

She doesn't close the laptop. She doesn't sleep, either.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - COURTYARD - DAY

Mia, pale, unslept, tells Desi an edited version of what happened. Desi doesn't need the unedited one to know something's wrong.

DESI

You need to talk to someone who
isn't going to tell you it was
the lighting.

MIA

Like a therapist.

DESI

(a beat)

Like my aunt's friend. Up in
Topanga. Not a Gilt-party-trick
person. The real thing. She won't
tell you what you want to hear.

MIA

That's not exactly a selling
point.

DESI

It's the only kind that's worth
anything.

MIA

(a shaky, grateful
laugh)

When did you get so sure about
all this.

DESI

Around the third 2 a.m. phone
call. I stopped waiting for you
to bring it up on your own.

EXT. TOPANGA CANYON - NAN'S PROPERTY - DAY

A house half-swallowed by the canyon, chimes, dogs that
don't bark at strangers because nothing about this place
is startled by anything anymore. NAN, 60s, weathered and
unhurried, waits on the porch like she was told to expect
company, because in the way that matters to her, she was.

NAN

You're later than I thought you'd
be.

MIA

You were expecting me?

NAN

I was expecting somebody. Come
sit.

INT. NAN'S HOUSE - TOPANGA CANYON - CONTINUOUS

A worn table, a deck of cards soft with handling. Nan lays
them without ceremony, none of Sable's showmanship, all of
it worse for the lack of theater.

She turns two cards. THE DEVIL. THE TOWER.

NAN

(flat, not unkind)

You already know what these mean.
You've known for weeks. You just
haven't let yourself finish the
sentence.

MIA

Tell me anyway.

NAN

I'm not going to tell you. I'm
going to show you.

She takes Mia's hand across the table. The room does not
go dark so much as it stops being entirely the room.

INT. THE MASQUE - VISION - TIMELESS

A ballroom that keeps almost ending and never does --
velvet walls the color of old wine, a clock on the far
wall whose hands move but whose hour never changes, doors
leading to rooms that lead back to this room. Masked
figures turn in a dance with no beginning anyone can
locate.

At the center of it: DIMITRIS, fifty-something now,
dressed exactly as he dresses at Gilt tonight -- the same
cut, the same practiced ease, worn twenty years past the
point where it reads as anything but costume.

He is dancing. He is always dancing, with someone new
every few turns, and every partner looks at him with the
exact hunger Mia recognized in her own chest three acts
ago.

The clock's hands sweep past midnight without the hour
changing. Nobody at the party notices they've been here
for what should have been a lifetime.

CLOSER ON DIMITRIS -- and here it starts. Not a jump cut,
not a trick of the light: his face AGES in real time, a
decade with every third turn of the dance, skin thinning,
gold going to gray.

Underneath the aging, nothing else moves at all. The same hand finds the same small of the same kind of back. The same practiced warmth lands on partner after partner after partner, frozen exactly as it is tonight, immune to the forty years crossing his face.

He is Dorian Gray with no portrait in an attic absorbing the cost. The cost is simply showing, in real time, on him -- and somehow that changes nothing about what he keeps doing.

The masked dancers thin out, one by one, walking away mid-song, unmasking as they go to reveal they were never anyone in particular -- Astrid's shape, Gen's shape, Talia's shape, Rae's shape, and others Mia doesn't recognize, decades of others, all walking out through doors that seal behind them.

He doesn't notice them leaving. He's already turning toward the next one.

By the final turn, the room is empty. The music hasn't stopped -- there's simply no one left to hear it end. Dimitris, ancient now, alone, keeps dancing with no one, arms shaped around an absence, face utterly hollow, still handsome in the bones of it, worshipped by nobody, in a room that has finally, completely, stopped watching.

He looks, for the first time in the whole vision, directly at Mia -- and for one frame, the look slides half a degree past her, past the edge of the vision itself, and lands somewhere that isn't hers to stand in. Gone before it can be confirmed. There is nothing behind his eyes that wants anything from her anymore. There is nothing behind his eyes at all.

INT. NAN'S HOUSE - TOPANGA CANYON - CONTINUOUS

Mia gasps back into the room, hand still gripped in Nan's, breathing like she's surfaced from underwater.

MIA

(shaken)

Is that going to happen to him?

NAN

That's not a curse I'm showing
you. That's just what happens to
a man who never once wanted to be
seen -- only worshipped and
desired.

MIA

Why show me. Not him.

NAN

Because he'd watch that and ask
who was filming it.

(a beat, gentler)

You're the only one in that room
who was ever going to do anything
but clap.

Mia sits with that. Something in her that's been asking to
be told it was crazy for months finally stops asking.

MIA

What do I do.

NAN

Stop trying to earn the seat at
his table. Start looking at who
else is sitting in it.

NAN (CONT'D)

(almost an
afterthought, already
refilling the kettle)

Ever hear the old story about the
boy who loved his own reflection
so much he couldn't leave the
pool.

MIA

Narcissus.

NAN

The nymph who loved him got the worse end of it. Cursed to only ever say back what he'd already said. By the end there was nothing left of her at all -- just a voice, bouncing off a canyon wall, waiting for somebody to talk first.

(a beat, looking at
Mia directly)

You're not going to be her.

EXT. TOPANGA CANYON - ROAD - DAY

Mia and Desi in Desi's car, winding back down out of the canyon. Mia's told her everything -- the vision, the cards, all of it -- and Desi hasn't said a word for a full mile.

DESI

(finally, carefully)

Okay. I believe you.

MIA

Just like that?

DESI

No, not just like that. I've watched you turn pale in a parking lot and lie awake for a week. I've also watched you draw a stranger's shoulder like you could feel what was in it. I don't think you're the kind of person who invents things. I think you're the kind of person who sees things other people have trained themselves not to.

MIA

That's a very generous way of saying you believe in ghosts now.

DESI
(a real laugh,
breaking the tension)
I believe in you. The ghosts can
figure themselves out.

Mia laughs too, the first easy laugh in weeks, and for one stretch of freeway it's just two friends in a car, ordinary, unafraid.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - PROFESSOR OKONKWO'S OFFICE - DAY

Office hours, nearly empty building. Mia sits across from Professor Okonkwo, notebook open, the DARK TETRAD diagram from the first lecture sketched again in the margin, more detailed now, annotated in her own handwriting.

MIA
Hypothetically. If someone
matched basically the whole
diagram. What's the actual next
step. Not the textbook answer.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO
(studying her, not
fooled by
"hypothetically" for a
second)
The textbook answer is boundaries
and documentation. The real
answer is that you stop trying to
get him to see himself clearly,
because that was never the goal,
and you start building a life he
isn't standing in the middle of.

MIA
That's it?

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

That's most of it. The rest is just time.

(gentler)

You're not the first student who's come to office hours with a "hypothetical" that has a name and a face. You won't be the last. That doesn't make it smaller. It just means you're not doing anything unusual by being caught in it.

MIA

I keep running the acronym. From the first week. Deny, attack, reverse. I can name every instance. Naming it hasn't made it stop working on me.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

(not unkind)

It won't. It just means you can stop negotiating with someone who was never actually in a negotiation.

It's the first time all semester someone has told Mia she isn't crazy without her having to convince them first.

INT. GEN'S APARTMENT - HOLLYWOOD HILLS - NIGHT

A smaller gathering, off the record, unwinding after a long week. String lights on the balcony, shoes off, the version of this crowd that only comes out once everyone's decided the night is safe enough to stop performing for. Mia, quieter than usual, actually watching instead of performing belonging. Gen and Talia, loose on wine, reminiscing.

TALIA

God, remember when it was just
you and him and that terrible
loft on Wilshire.

GEN

(a private smile,
unguarded)

Don't. That was ten years and
about forty pounds of my dignity
ago.

TALIA

You were so gone for him.

GEN

(catching herself,
brushing it off)

We were kids.

It's nothing. It's everything. Mia hears the specific weight in "you and him," the tense of it, the decade folded into four words, and for the first time she isn't flattered by proximity to this history. She's counting it.

Across the room, Rae watches Mia watching Gen, and makes a decision.

INT. GEN'S APARTMENT - BALCONY - CONTINUOUS

Rae follows Mia out for air. Doesn't waste time on small talk.

RAE

You're starting to see it.

MIA

See what.

RAE

Don't do that. Not with me.

A long beat. Mia decides to trust her, mostly because she's out of better options.

MIA

How long ago. You and him.

RAE

(the guilt finally
given somewhere to go)

Once. Years ago. I've watched
every version of this since and
told myself it wasn't my business
to say anything.

(harder on herself
than Mia is)

It was always my business. I just
didn't want to be the one who
blew it up.

MIA

Why tell me now.

RAE

Because Nan sent you to me. She
doesn't send people places by
accident.

For the first time since this started, Mia has an ally who
isn't performing anything.

INT. GEN'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Back inside. Gen, refilling her glass, catches something
in Rae's face as she comes back in from the balcony -- a
shift, small, unreadable to anyone who hasn't spent a
decade in these exact rooms.

GEN

(too casual)

You two get along.

RAE

(careful)

She's easy to talk to.

GEN

(a beat, something
colder underneath the
wine now)

Careful what you talk about.

It isn't a threat, exactly. It's worse -- an old reflex, protecting a story Gen's spent ten years deciding to believe, aimed instinctively at anyone who might crack it.

INT. DIMITRIS'S LOFT - ARTS DISTRICT - NIGHT

Dimitris alone, working the phone the way he works a room -- calm, unhurried, in complete control of a conversation the other party doesn't know is a conversation yet.

DIMITRIS

(into the phone, warm,
concerned)

Astrid. Hey. Listen, I don't want you hearing this somewhere weird, but I think the intern's been saying some things. About us. I don't think it's malicious, I think she's just -- young, and maybe read more into something than was there.

He listens, nodding along to a reaction we don't hear, already three moves ahead of it.

DIMITRIS (CONT'D)

No, don't do anything. I just wanted you to have it from me first, before it gets to you some other way and sounds worse than it is.

He hangs up, sets the phone down, and pours himself a drink, unbothered, already thinking about something else entirely. He hasn't lied, technically, about a single fact. He's just decided which direction the truth points, and made sure he got there first.

Days later, that phone call has already finished its work -- a rumor doesn't need to be true to travel, only to be first.

INT. ASTRID'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - NIGHT (EARLIER)

Astrid alone at her own mirror, getting ready, running through what she'll say tonight like rehearsing a part. She stops mid-motion, mascara wand in hand, and looks at her own reflection a beat too long -- the specific look of someone who suspects the story she's about to perform and the story that's actually true are not the same story, and has decided, deliberately, not to find out which.

She finishes her makeup. Whatever crossed her face is gone by the time she's done.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - EMPLOYEE HALLWAY - NIGHT (SAME TIME)

Talia, off the clock for one minute, catches her own reflection in the dark glass of a service door. Six years of running that rope pass over her face in the space of a breath -- every intern, every Astrid, every version of this exact rumor she's watched arrive on cue like weather.

She doesn't say anything out loud. She doesn't need to. She straightens her jacket, puts the clipboard face back on, and goes back to work, filing this one away with all the others, except this time, for reasons she couldn't yet explain to anyone who asked, she doesn't quite manage to file it all the way down.

INT. GILT - MEZZANINE - NIGHT (LATER)

The rope doesn't lift the same way for Mia tonight. She feels it a full ten seconds before she understands it -- the pause a beat too long, Talia's eyes sliding past her toward someone for permission that doesn't used to be necessary.

At the table, Astrid holds court now, not Gen. Something has shifted in the group's weather, and Mia is standing in the wrong side of it.

ASTRID
(cool, performing
generosity for the
table)

Mia. We were just talking about
you.

MIA
Good things, I hope.

ASTRID
(a beat, letting the
room feel it)
We were talking about how you
told half the interns you and
Dimitris were basically engaged.
Before you'd even been here two
months.

MIA
That's not true. I never said
that.

ASTRID
That's exactly what someone who
said it would say.

The table doesn't defend her. Gen looks at her glass.
Talía looks at the door. Mia understands, with total
clarity, that the story doesn't have to be true. It only
has to be the one everyone's already decided to believe.

Dimitris arrives late to this, unbothered, sliding into
the seat beside Astrid instead of Mia for the first time
in months -- a small, silent verdict the whole table reads
instantly.

Across the table, Rae gets the same treatment in miniature
-- Talía's eyes sliding past her the exact way they just
slid past Mia, Gen not offering her the seat she's had for
years. Nobody says why. Nobody has to.

Rae catches Mia's eye once, and gives her the smallest
possible nod -- solidarity, and an apology, and a warning,

all in one motion too small for anyone else at the table to clock.

EXT. MALIBU ESTATE - GATE - DAY

Mia, the brass key from the toast in hand, buzzed at a gate she's never had to buzz at before. A PROPERTY MANAGER, not unkind, meets her there instead of letting her in.

PROPERTY MANAGER

I've been asked to collect that,
actually.

MIA

(quiet)

Of course you have.

She hands it over without a fight. There was never a version of this where the room was actually hers, and some part of her knew that the whole time and let herself believe it anyway.

INT. MIA'S CAR - PARKED - DAY

Mia, engine off outside the estate gate, watches her phone do to her, in the space of one afternoon, what it took months to build. A group chat she's no longer added to, visible only by its absence. Gen's name, grayed out. Talia's number, still there, unanswered for the first time ever within the hour.

A calendar invite for Sable Reyes's birthday, quietly uninvited, the way things get uninvited now -- not a message, just a silence where an invitation used to arrive automatically.

She doesn't cry over any single one of them. It's the total, arriving all at once, that lands -- an entire second life switched off from a control panel she never got to see, let alone touch.

She sets the phone in the cup holder, face-down, and drives to work anyway, because nobody's told her yet that

there won't be a job to go back to either.

INT. HALCYON MUTUAL - HR OFFICE - DAY

Mia, called in without warning, across the desk from an HR REPRESENTATIVE holding a printed complaint.

HR REPRESENTATIVE

There've been concerns raised about boundary issues with a supervisor. Given the nature of the claims department's workload, we think it's best your internship concludes early.

MIA

He propositioned me. He's the one who --

HR REPRESENTATIVE

(not unkind, already closed)

Mr. Xydias has an excellent record here. We take all concerns seriously, which is why we're handling this quietly, for everyone's sake.

Mia understands, in real time, that "quietly" means her, not him. She leaves the building for the last time that afternoon with a box of desk items she barely remembers packing.

EXT. HALCYON MUTUAL - PLAZA - CONTINUOUS

Mia on a low wall outside the building, box in her lap, staring at nothing. Her phone buzzes -- Desi, already calling before Mia's even texted her.

MIA

(answering, voice not fully steady)

How did you know.

DESI (V.O.)
(over the phone)
I didn't. I just had a bad
feeling since Tuesday. Where are
you.

MIA
Outside the building.

DESI (V.O.)
Don't move. I'm coming.

Mia sits with the phone still against her ear long after
the call's ended, the first small mercy this act has
offered her.

INT. MIA'S CAR - PARKED - NIGHT

Mia, box still in the passenger seat, calls her mother
before she's decided what version of the truth she's ready
to say out loud.

MOTHER (V.O.)
(over the phone, warm,
immediately alert to
something wrong)
Baby, what happened.

MIA
I lost the internship. It's fine.
It wasn't a good fit anymore.

MOTHER (V.O.)
(a beat, gentle, not
fooled)
Is this the supervisor.

Mia doesn't answer right away, which is its own answer.

MOTHER (V.O.) (CONT'D)
(quiet)
You don't have to tell me the
whole thing tonight.

A long pause down the line, static and breathing.

MOTHER (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Remember Katie Broussard's
library card.

MIA

(quiet, the first real
crack in her voice all
day)

I remember.

MOTHER (V.O.)

I still owe you an apology for
calling that kindness. Come home
for a weekend. Not to hide. Just
to remember what your own kitchen
sounds like.

MIA

(a small, real laugh
through the tears)

Okay. Soon.

She hangs up, sits in the dark a moment, and for the first time all day, the tears actually come -- not performed for anyone, not held back for anyone either.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT

Mia alone, the corkboard of ticket stubs behind her looking like evidence of a life that belonged to someone else. No job, no table, no Astrid-shaped enemy she can even properly blame, because the person who built all of it is still, somehow, the only one nobody is angry at.

Her phone buzzes. A text from an unknown number, brief, cruel, anonymous enough to be anyone at that table.

INSERT - PHONE SCREEN

UNKNOWN NUMBER

everyone knows what you are now

BACK TO SCENE

She sets the phone face-down. Doesn't cry, not yet -- just sits very still in the dark, the way she sat cross-legged on this same floor four acts ago, except this time there's no frequency to tune that fixes anything.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - NIGHT

Mia in front of her closet, an invitation she wasn't sent propped against the mirror -- she found out about tonight from Desi, who found out from a mutual, who found out the way everyone eventually finds out about the night that matters most to Dimitris every year.

Her phone rings. NAN'S NAME on the screen. Mia almost doesn't pick up.

MIA
(answering)
I wasn't going to go.

NAN (V.O.)
(over the phone,
unhurried)
I didn't call to talk you out of
it.

MIA
Then why'd you call.

NAN (V.O.)
To remind you what loses to him.
Fear. Shame. An audience. Don't
bring him any of the three and
you'll already have done more
than anyone in that room has
managed in years.

MIA

That's it? That's the whole plan?

NAN (V.O.)

It's not a plan. It's a posture.
It's the only one that's ever
worked on something like him.

The line goes quiet. Mia looks at herself in the mirror a long moment -- then reaches past the invitation and takes the plainest thing in her closet off the hanger instead of the nicest.

A knock at the door. Desi, uninvited, already dressed to go with her.

DESI

You weren't seriously going to do
this alone.

MIA

(a real, grateful
breath)

I was seriously going to try.

DESI

Bad plan. New plan: I stand near
the exit and glare at anyone who
looks at you wrong. That's the
whole extent of my skill set
tonight.

MIA

(the first real smile
in weeks)

That's actually exactly what I
need.

DESI

I know. That's why I offered.

INT. RAE'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A smaller place than Gen's, tidier, no gold ribbon anywhere in it. RAE stands in front of her own mirror in a plain black dress, unmoving, the invitation propped on her dresser exactly the way Mia's was.

Six years of silence sit in the room with her. She picks up her phone, scrolls to a text thread she has never once answered -- HIM, going back further than the app remembers -- and, for the first time, doesn't open it.

She sets the phone down screen-first, the same gesture Mia made three acts ago without either of them knowing it. Some postures get learned twice, in different rooms, for the same reason.

RAE
(to her own
reflection, quiet,
testing the word)
Six years.

She doesn't flinch from it. That's new. She picks up her keys.

EXT. GILT - NIGHT

Banners nobody would ever call banners -- gold ribbon strung along the brick, a sign at the door that says nothing except a date. Everyone in this line knows exactly whose night it is without it needing to be printed anywhere. Half birthday, half coronation, thrown every year by people who've never once questioned why.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - NIGHT

The room is fuller than Mia has ever seen it. Gen's table sits at the center of the floor tonight instead of above it, a throne brought down to mingle with its subjects. Astrid at Dimitris's side, restored to her seat, performing recovered exactly the way she performs everything.

Dimitris holds court at the center of it, mid-toast to nobody in particular yet, the whole room orbiting him the way it always has, the way it's about to stop.

DIMITRIS

(raising a glass,
warming up the room)

Every year I say the same thing.
Every year it's still true. This
room only works because the
people in it decide, every single
time, to show up for it.

The room laughs, warm, easy, the applause it's always given him arriving right on cue.

Mia enters. Alone, unannounced, no rope lifting for her, no invitation extended. She's not here to be let in. She's just here.

The effect ripples outward before she's said a word to anyone. Talia sees her first, goes still. Gen follows her sightline.

Astrid crosses the room fast, positioning herself between Mia and the table like a door closing.

ASTRID

You have some nerve.

MIA

(calm -- not
performing calm,
actually calm)

I'm not here for him.

ASTRID

(louder than she means
to, playing to the
room now)

Everyone already knows what you
did. What you told people. That
you two were basically engaged,
two months in, like some pathetic

--

She's said this before, word for word, and it's landed
before. Tonight, mid-sentence, something else surfaces
behind it -- an old memory, unbidden.

ASTRID (CONT'D)

(faltering, the memory
arriving louder than
the accusation)

He said -- he told me the same
thing. Almost exactly. "I wasn't
going to let you hear it from
someone else before you heard it
from me." That's -- he doesn't
just say things like that to
anyone, that's not a thing you --

She stops. Hears herself. GEN has gone very still beside
her.

GEN

(quiet, cold with
recognition)

He said that to me too. Ten years
ago. Almost those exact words.

TALIA

(barely audible)

Me too.

The three of them look at each other, and for one
terrible, silent second, ten years of separately held
certainty collapses into the same shape at once. Not
information Mia gave them. Information they already had,
finally set down next to each other's.

Rae steps forward from the edge of the room, done watching.

RAE

(steady, no longer
protecting anyone)

It's not a coincidence. I heard
it too. Six years ago.

ASTRID

(quieter now, the last
piece falling in on
top of the first)

"I don't usually let people in."
He said that to me the second
month.

GEN

(hollow)

Third week, for me.

TALIA

(flat)

First night.

To Mia's ear, trained on exactly this kind of thing, the four voices don't land one after another the way separate sentences should. They land on top of each other, the same handful of words layering into something closer to a chord than an argument -- four women who spent years each holding one thread of the same sentence, finally letting it ring out together instead of alone.

For the first time since any of them can name, it doesn't sound like an echo. It sounds like a room full of people talking at the same volume.

The silence that follows spreads outward from the four of them like weather, faster than sound, the way a room learns something is wrong before anyone has said what.

DIMITRIS crosses the floor toward the disturbance, easy at first, ready to redirect this the way he redirects everything -- a hand halfway to Astrid's shoulder, a warm

word already forming.

It doesn't land. Nobody softens. For the first time in this room, in his own room, on his own night, the knob he always finds simply isn't there to turn.

For one unguarded second, something old and hollow surfaces behind his eyes -- the same hollowness from the vision, decades early, arriving right on schedule. Behind him, every candle in the room leans the same direction at once, away from him, like a room full of small flames trying to put distance between themselves and something that just stopped pretending to be warm.

DIMITRIS

(too smooth, half a
beat too late)

This is -- everyone's had a lot
to drink. Let's not do this here.

Nobody moves to agree with him. That has never happened before in this room, and he doesn't have a version of himself built to handle it.

GEN

(quiet, to him, not
the room -- the only
sentence she gives him
all night)

Ten years, Dimitris. Same
sentence. You didn't even bother
writing a new one.

DIMITRIS

(a flicker of real
panic under the charm
now)

Gen. Come on. You know me.

GEN

(a terrible, small
laugh)

I really thought I did. That's
the part I'm going to have to sit
with.

TALIA

(not looking at him at
all, already gathering
her things)

I ran your door for six years.
Free of charge, apparently, since
I was on the list too.

DIMITRIS

Talia --

She doesn't wait for the rest of it. Neither does Gen.

Mia hasn't said a single word this whole time. She isn't
gloating. She isn't afraid. She's simply still standing
there, watching, giving the room nothing to perform
against -- no fear to feed on, no shame to weaponize,
nothing.

That absence is the loudest thing in the building.

Gen turns and walks away from the table without a word --
not to Mia, not to Dimitris, just away. Talia follows a
beat later. The crowd around them, sensing the shift the
way a crowd always eventually does, thins, conversations
picking back up half a decibel too loud, eyes sliding past
him instead of toward him.

By the time the song changes, Dimitris Xydias is standing
near-alone at the center of the room he built his whole
life to fill, and it is, for the first time anyone here
has ever seen, simply not filling.

INT. GILT - LADIES' ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Astrid, alone at the mirror, shaking, mascara starting to run. Mia enters behind her -- not in triumph, just because this is where she ended up.

A long beat. Neither of them performs anything for the other this time.

MIA

I never meant to hurt you. I didn't know about you when it started. I know that doesn't fix anything.

ASTRID

(hard, immediate, no opening)

Don't. Don't stand there and make yourself the good one. You knew eventually. You stayed anyway.

MIA

You're right. I did.

Astrid wipes under her eyes, furious at her own face for betraying her.

ASTRID

I don't want your apology. I want my life back the way it was before either of you existed in it, and you can't give me that, so I don't actually want anything from you at all.

MIA

Okay.

ASTRID

(a last, brittle edge)

I still think you're exactly what people are saying you are.

She leaves. Whatever door was briefly open between them in a different bathroom, months ago, is closed now, permanently, on Astrid's terms. Mia lets her go. Some things don't get to end clean, and she's done expecting them to.

She looks at herself in the mirror -- steady, tired, finally, unmistakably her own. She raises one hand, fingers spread, and presses it flat against the glass -- a gold bathroom light, a hand against a mirror, a shape the night has been circling back to since before she knew its name.

A hairline crack races out from under her palm, corner to corner, silent. This time nothing looks back out of it that isn't her.

MIA
(quiet, to no one)

Mia.

She says her own name the way he used to say it, testing its weight -- and takes it back on the way out.

INT. GILT - MAIN ROOM - LATER

Dimitris, alone at the bar now, phone already lit in his hand, thumb already moving -- a new name, a new number, the machine restarting before the last one's even finished falling apart. He hasn't lost everything. He's lost this room, tonight, and he will already be somewhere else building the next one by morning.

Behind him, in the long mirror over the bar, the dark wisp gathers itself off his shoulders, unhurried, patient the way something waits outside a door it already knows will open -- and slides free of him entirely, pooling along the mirror's edge like something deciding whether he's still worth the trouble of wearing. It doesn't leave the room. It isn't finished being hungry. It's simply, for tonight, between hosts.

Mia doesn't wait to watch that part. She's already at the door.

EXT. GILT - NIGHT

She walks out past the line still forming, past people who don't know yet what just happened three feet past that door, and doesn't look back at the building even once.

INT. CALLOWAY COLLEGE - PROFESSOR OKONKWO'S OFFICE - DAY

Nearly empty building again, same office, different Mia sitting across the desk than the one who came in with a careful "hypothetically" weeks ago.

MIA

I'm withdrawing from the semester. I wanted to tell you in person, not just email it.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

(unsurprised, studying her)

You look steadier than you did last time you sat in that chair.

MIA

I feel steadier. I also feel like I'm running.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

Sometimes those are the same thing wearing different clothes. Running toward something and running away from it can look identical from the outside. Only you know which one this is.

MIA

Does it matter which, if I end up somewhere better either way?

PROFESSOR OKONKWO

(a small, real smile)

No. It doesn't, actually. That might be the first useful thing I've told you that isn't in any textbook.

She stands, offers a hand instead of the desk between them.

PROFESSOR OKONKWO (CONT'D)

Go count the wreckage from a safe distance for a while. Come back and finish the degree whenever it's a want again instead of a hide.

Mia shakes her hand, holds onto the sentence the way she once held onto the Dark Tetrad diagram -- something to underline twice and carry out the door.

INT. MIA'S APARTMENT - ECHO PARK - DAY

Boxes. Not many -- she never accumulated much that mattered. The corkboard comes down last, ticket stubs and postcards going into a single folder instead of the trash. Some of it's worth keeping. Not all of it.

In the same drawer as the ticket stubs, she finds the folded sketchbook page from the false-peak weeks -- the waxen, bottomless-eyed face she drew and hid and never looked at again. She unfolds it, studies it a long moment without flinching this time, and instead of tearing it up, sets it on the desk beside her keyboard.

On impulse, she hums the shape of it into her phone's voice memo -- four bars, unfinished, a melody with a name it hasn't earned yet. She saves the file. Doesn't title it. Some things get named later, once they're far enough away to be looked at whole.

Desi sits on the one remaining chair, watching her work.

DESI

You don't have to leave the whole
city over one guy.

MIA

(taping a box shut,
not looking up)

I keep picturing the billboard on
the 101. The one with the family.
I used to drive past it every day
and never once read it.

(a beat)

I don't want to live somewhere
I've stopped reading the signs.

DESI

Where, then?

MIA

Haven't looked yet. First place
with no billboards I already know
by heart.

Her phone buzzes on the packed-up desk. A text from Rae --
no explanation needed for either of them anymore.

INSERT - PHONE SCREEN

RAE

Left Gilt for good. Told Gen why.
She didn't want to hear it, but I
said it anyway. That's more than
I've done in years. Go build
whatever's next. You earned the
exit.

BACK TO SCENE

Mia reads it twice, sets the phone down, and finishes
taping the last box without needing to reply right away.
Some gratitude doesn't need an audience either.

EXT. TOPANGA CANYON - NAN'S PROPERTY - DAY (LATER)

One last stop before the freeway. Nan on the porch again, unsurprised, the way she's unsurprised by everything.

NAN

You'll come back to this canyon
someday. Not for me. For
yourself, once you've got
something worth reading in the
cards again.

MIA

How do you know I'll come back at
all?

NAN

(a small, knowing
smile)

Because you're the kind who
climbs back up and still wants to
know what was down there.

MIA

What do I even call what happened
to me. Victim doesn't fit
anymore. Survivor doesn't either,
not really.

NAN

(unhurried, turning
the word over like a
stone she's had in her
pocket a while)

Alchemist, if you want one.
Gold's just lead that got held in
the fire long enough.

MIA

That's a lot to live up to.

NAN

It's not a job. It's just what
you already are.

They don't hug. Nan isn't a hugging kind of Seer. She just nods, once, like a door closing gently instead of slamming, and Mia gets back in her car.

EXT. LOS ANGELES - FREEWAY OVERPASS - DUSK

Mia's car, packed, heading out. In the side mirror, downtown's skyline catches the last orange light and, for one flickering second, wavers behind something like heat-shimmer -- glass, or a screen, or a dome none of it was ever quite outside of.

It steadies. It's just the light. It was always, also, never just the light.

She doesn't look in the mirror again.

INT. BARE APARTMENT - UNNAMED CITY - NIGHT (LATER)

A new room, mostly empty, a single lamp, a mattress on the floor, one speaker instead of four. No corkboard yet. No name on the buzzer that anyone here would recognize.

Mia sits cross-legged on the floor exactly the way she sat on a different floor, three weeks and a whole life ago, headphones on, one hand resting on a knob she isn't turning yet. The single lamp throws one shadow behind her, only ever one, exactly the length it should be.

This time, when she nudges it, the sound that comes out is entirely new -- nothing looped, nothing borrowed, nothing performing anything for anyone who isn't in the room.

She closes her eyes. Doesn't brace for anything. Just listens.

FADE OUT.

THE END